



IMRAN WAJID RHINOPLASTY

Twenty three-year-old Imran Wajid still remembers the excruciating pain inflicted by a swinging bat as he kept wicket in Class VI. The accidental swing of the bat also left his nose crooked for many years. "Every time I saw myself in the mirror, I felt awful. Though my folks at home always tried to reassure me, I would feel ill-at-ease in front of people," he says. The decision to go for nose correction (rhinoplasty) recently was his own. He shelled out Rs 40,000 for the four-hour operation. But it was worth the effort. He had had a thorough nose job done by Dr M.S. Venkatesh (above), Sagar Apollo Hospital, Bangalore. "I nearly jumped with joy when I saw myself in the mirror," he smiles. Dealing with clients and customers has become easier, feels the man who runs a construction company. "The operation made me a new person," he says.

painstakingly building up the patient profile. Sharing with INDIA TODAY the first-of-its-kind study on aesthetic plastic surgery trends, he says, "Delhi being a melting pot, the results of our study on 600 patients between 2004 and 2007 can be considered a true reflection of the Indian scenario." Check out the data: in 2004, there were 25 per cent male vis-à-vis 75 per cent female patients. Male footfall today is 30 per cent, while female pace has slackened to 70. The surge in demand was fuelled largely by the age group of 25-45 years. "This is when one is most active and appearance matters a lot," he says. About 84 per cent men are from urban areas and 88 per cent unmarried (as opposed to 43 per cent of unmarried women); 70 per cent are socially and financially independent (plastic surgery textbooks use the acronym SIMON for Single, Immature, Male, Overly-expectant, Narcissistic men). "If one were to believe the tabloids, plastic surgery would appear to be a luxury indulged in mainly by the elite," mentions Choudhury. "In reality, 67 per cent of our patients come from the

"Access, affluence and affordability are the key to the plastic surgery boom."

DR M.S. VENKATESH, BANGALORE

middle class. Consciousness of appearance, obviously, knows no class boundaries. The middle class is clearly driving the boom."

And it's not just the metro male. Young males are making a beeline for plastic surgeons in small towns too. Ahmedabad hardly had eight cosmetic surgeons till the mid-1990s. Today the number has crossed 50. So what's sending the Ahmedabad male to plastic surgeons? "In most cases it is the girlfriend who tells the man to get an acne mark removed or to straighten out his nose," says plastic surgeon Dr Hemant Saraiya. "Earlier men would try yoga to look better. Today they don't hesitate to go for surgery and are also pretty clued-up about it," observes another surgeon, Dr Shrikant Lagwankar. Earlier this year, Saraiya operated on Dilip Rana for flattening his belly. Rana had a lucrative job offer in the pipeline, where he